

problem, for me, was the way buying stuff made me feel. Whenever I experienced low moods or felt like a failure, acquiring something I desired was a jolt for my self-esteem. And then, in the way that addictive habits develop, I couldn't do for long without that thrill, and in happy times I would reward myself with the same kick.

Now that I live on pocket money, and ration out my daily expenses, I have come to understand that the highest points in my life have been unrelated to material possessions. It sounds stupidly simplistic, but going back to the basics is the foundation of the pocket money strategy; you start small to rebuild, big time.

At the start of the savings plan, I wrote down all of the occasions I recalled feeling content, loved, intelligent, accomplished, attractive and confident, and what was going on in my life at the time that made me feel so. Not one of those 'highs' correlated to how much money I had in the bank, or how I looked.

Contentedness was laughing with my friends; love was my family, in every sense; intelligence was finishing a task at work that I gave my best to; a sense of accomplishment was soothing my baby niece to sleep when she had been crying; attractiveness was being with partners who looked me in the eye, not at the outfit I had on; and confidence was me being at my fittest and healthiest.

With this new understanding of how I measured myself-worth, I realised I could easily live on \$200 a week.

Part 5: You need a hero

The gatekeeper is the account holder into whose name your salary is deposited, and who then rations out your pocket money.

My parents, in a testament to my close relationship with them, were the logical choice to be my financial champions. Your partner, sibling or best friend might be the person you choose to back you on this endeavour. You might also consider an independent financial planner as the more sensible choice for your circumstances – I would have booked an appointment with one had I not had a strong relationship with my parents.

The role of your gatekeeper is to: